JAMMU-SIZED WELCOME



In a remarkable turnaround in Hindu-majority Jammu, locals, including the traders, are showering CM **Omar Abdullah** with praise for restoring a centuries-old practice—the traditional winter darbar move when the government shifts from Srinagar to Jammu. It was scrapped in 2021 by L-G Manoj Sinha, leaving the winter economy gasping. For decades, Jammu had viewed the annual shift with resentment, seeing it as a symbol of Kashmir's political dominance. But this revival, and the growing influence of Abdullah's deputy from Jammu, Surinder Choudhary, have changed the mood.



LADIES FIRST

The Ladli Behna Yojana, a monthly dole programme for women in MP, proved such a poll bonanza for the BJP that it was replicated in a number of states. Now Madhya Pradesh CM **Mohan Yadav**—who hiked the payout from Rs 1,250 to Rs 1,500—is considering renaming it Devi Subhadra Yojana, the second renaming of a Shivraj Chouhan-era scheme after CM Rise Schools became Sandipani Schools. Both names draw from Krishna lore—Subhadra was Krishna's sister, and Sandipani his guru—signalling a deliberate Yadav-centric symbolic shift.

SOLO VOYAGE



After the Karur rally tragedy involving his Thamizhaga Vetri Kazhagam (TVK), rumours had swirled that superstar **Vijay** was inching toward the AIADMK-BJP alliance. Both parties had reportedly sent "multiple feelers", but now with TVK's categorical declaration of Vijay as its CM candidate, the door has been slammed shut. The message is clear: the TVK supremo is neither leaning toward a Dravidian heavyweight nor bowing to saffron pressure.

Kaushik Deka with Avishek G. Dastidar, Kaleem Geelani, Rahul Noronha and Kavitha Muralidharan

SCIENCE WATCH

By **Jumana Shah**

FROM DNA TO DIAGNOSIS
MAPPING THE TRIBAL GENE

In a national first, Gujarat has announced a large-scale genome sequencing project focused on its tribal population to enhance healthcare outcomes. Led by the Gujarat Biotechnology Research Centre, the 'Creation of Reference Genome Database for Tribal Population in Gujarat' is a state initiative to complement the national Genome India Project launched in 2020 by the Dept of Biotechnology, Ministry of Science and Technology. The broader goal is to map India's genetic diversity by sequencing genomes of 10,000 healthy individuals across major ethnic groups.



SHUTTERSTOCK

CELL TO CELL Rathwa tribals at the annual 'Kawant' festival

Starting in early 2026, researchers will collect biological samples from over 4,000 tribals across 17 districts and 31 communities—from the Dang forests in the south to the tribal belts of Sabarkantha in the north. About half the samples will undergo whole genome sequencing, building a reference database of around 2,000 genomes. Alongside, health profiles, age, sex, and hereditary disease data will be gathered to study genetic links to conditions such as sickle cell anaemia, thalassemia, G6PD (an enzyme vital for protecting red blood cells) deficiency, and certain cancers prevalent among tribal groups.

By identifying mutations and carriers, genome sequencing can also reduce diagnostic costs—from Rs 1 lakh to Rs 1,000-1,500—enable early detection, and allow preventive care. It can also guide doctors to choose effective drugs and avoid adverse reactions, ultimately advancing precision medicine for underserved populations.